

Ava Q. Ma de Sousa
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EDUCATION

PhD in Social Psychology Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences Emphasis <i>University of California, Santa Barbara</i>	2027 (Expected) <i>Santa Barbara, United States</i>
Research MSc in Brain and Cognitive Sciences, cum laude <i>University of Amsterdam</i>	2021 <i>Amsterdam, Netherlands</i>
BSc in Cognitive Sciences & Psychology, with high distinction <i>University of Toronto</i>	2019 <i>Toronto, Canada</i>

FELLOWSHIPS, GRANTS, AWARDS & HONORS

P.E.O. Scholar Award (25,000 USD)	2026-2027
UCSB Graduate Division Dissertation Fellowship (10,800 USD)	2026
Social Sciences & Humanities Research Council Doctoral Fellowship (120,000 CAD)	2022-2026
Charles G. McClintock Award	2026
Humanities and Social Sciences Research Grant (3,000 USD)	2026
International Society for Research on Emotion Travel Grant (1,000 USD)	2026
Academic Senate Doctoral Student Travel Grant (Domestic) (900 USD)	2026
SPSP Graduate Registration Stipend	2026
SANS Diversity Travel Award (500 USD)	2025
UCSB Graduate Student Association Travel Grant (500 USD) x3	2023-25
International Doctoral Recruitment Fellowship, UCSB	2021
Early Career Fund Grant, Master Brain & Cognitive Sciences (70 EUR)	2021
Mind and Brain Award, Master Brain & Cognitive Sciences (200 EUR)	2020
Anna And Alex Beverly Memorial Fellowship (2,000 CAD)	2019-2020
Arts & Science Student Union Travel Grant (200 CAD)	2019
Dean's List Scholar at the University of Toronto	2016-2019
Louis Savlov Scholarship In Sciences And Humanities (300 CAD)	2017
University of Toronto Scholar's Award (6,000 CAD)	2015
Warren Goldring Residence Scholarship (1,100 CAD)	2015

PRE-PRINTS, PUBLICATIONS IN PREP & UNDER REVIEW

Doriscar, J., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, Hoard, L., Perry, S. Gardner, W., Brady, W. (Pre-print). Invisible Wounds: Superhumanization of Black Victims is Associated with Less Moral Outrage in Response to Racial Injustice. https://osf.io/preprints/psyarxiv/m3g4j_v1

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Tellefsen S., McCray I., Howard S. (*Submitted*). When Injustice Mobilizes or Demobilizes: The Conditional Effects of Vicarious Racism on Collective Action Across Racial Groups.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (*In prep*). Self-Model Reliability and Neural Correlates of Social Prediction.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp, B. D., Pruessner, L., Garcés Espinosa, M.S., Romos, G., Clark, M.S., B. D., Koopman-Holm, B., Yu, H. (*In prep*). How cultural and relational norms underlie social emotion generation.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Thapar, S., Qin, T., Chen, A. X., Zhao, S., Yu, H. (*In prep*). Shifting Relational Norms in the U.S. and China Across the 20th Century.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Okhan, M., Molinaro, A., Sznycer, D., Yu, H. (*In prep*). Neural Representations of Criminal Severity Across 4,000 Years of Legal History.

PUBLICATIONS

Howard S., Tellefsen S., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, McCray I. (2026). The Relationship Between Black Americans' Recent and Lifetime Exposure to Vicarious Racism and Past and Future Collective Action Behaviors. *Scientific Reports*. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41598-026-48864-x>

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Furtado Fernandes, L., Ford, E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2025). Loneliness is associated with unstable and distorted emotion transition predictions. *Communications Psychology*. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s44271-025-00310-w>

Alea Albada, N., Woods, V. E., German, T., & **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.** (2025). Gaining insights: Learning about introduction to psychology from former students' personal stories. In R. R. Totton & C. A. Sanderson (Eds.), *Teaching introduction to psychology*. Edward Elgar Publishing.

Ma de Sousa, A. Q., & Yu, H. (2025). A framework for studying the conceptual structure of human relationships. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences*. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S1364661325000750>

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Chang, J., Lu, C, Li, W., Zhou, X., Yu, H. How are social emotions computed in relational contexts? Invited Long Abstract Submission. *Affective Science* (2023).

Chang, L. A., Armaos, K., Warns, L., **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.**, Paauwe, F., Scholz, C., & Engelmann, J. B. (2023). Mentalizing in an economic games context is associated with enhanced activation and connectivity in left temporoparietal junction. *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience*. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10243902/>

Loinaz, I., Barboni-Pekmezian, L., **Ma de Sousa, A.** (2020) Gender differences in child to parent violence risk factors. *Anales de Psicología*, 36 (3), 408-417.

Loinaz, I., **Ma de Sousa, A.** (2020). Assessing risk factors in clinical and judicial child-to-parent violence cases. *European Journal of Psychology Applied to Legal Context*, 12 (1), 43-51.

Loinaz, I., Bigas, N., **Ma de Sousa, A.** (2019) Comparing Intra and Extra-Familial Child Abuse in a Forensic Context. *Psicothema*, 31 (3), 271-276.

INVITED TALKS

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck M. E., Baek, Burns S. M., E. B., Yu H. (2026, July). *Relational emotions: from computations of social emotion across cultures, to processing distortions of loneliness*. Cognition and Philosophy Lab, Monash University PI: Jakob Hohwy. Melbourne, Australia.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, May). *Behavioral and neural patterns of predicting emotion transitions: The moderating role of loneliness*. Princeton Social Neuroscience Lab, PI: Diana Tamir. Princeton, NJ.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. (2026, April). *What We Owe Each Other: A Computational Model of Relational Norms, Moral Judgments and Social Emotions Across Cultures*. PEO Santa Barbara Chapter Meeting. Santa Barbara, CA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, March). *Behavioral and neural patterns of predicting emotion transitions: The moderating role of loneliness*. Columbia Social Neuroscience Lab, PI: Meghan Meyer. New York, NY.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2026, March). *Relational emotions: from computations of social emotion across cultures, to processing distortions of loneliness*. Toronto Decision Neuroscience Lab, PI: Cendri Hutcherson. Toronto, ON.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu H. (2025, May). *Relational Emotions*. Center for Evolutionary Psychology. Santa Barbara, CA.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp. B., Yu H. (2026, July). *Social Emotions in Relational Context: A Cross-Cultural Computational Approach*. International Society for Research on Emotion Conference; Brisbane, Australia.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2026, March). *The Moderating Role of Loneliness on Emotion Transition Predictions* in Symposium: Understanding Others' Emotions: Neural Mechanisms, Structured Beliefs, and Social Context (Chair: **Ma de Sousa, A. Q.**). Society of Affective Science Annual Conference; Pittsburgh, PA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Earp. B., Yu H. (2026, March). *A computational model predicting experiences of gratitude and pride across relationships and cultures*. Positive Emotions Preconference at Society of Affective Science Annual Conference; Pittsburgh, PA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Cui Q., Welborne, B.L., Hong, Y., Ratner, K.G. (2024, April). *Affective and motivational effects of social identity threats*. Social Affective Neuroscience Society Annual Conference, Toronto, Canada.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. Albada, N., German, T., Woods, V. (2023, October). *Bridging the Gap Between the Novice and Experienced Learner with Peer Insight Discussion Videos*. Engaging Teaching Symposium, Santa Barbara, CA.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. Grisco, M., Butler, F. V., Padilla-Garcia, D., Ratner, K.G. (2023, April). *How social identity influences perceptions of and reactions to blatant racism*. Western Psychological Association Convention, Riverside, CA.

Jonušaitė, I., Kühn M., **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, Pingouras, A., Zimmerman, M. M. L., Campdepadrós Barrios J., Carbello, D., Steijger, M. Stojanović, M. (2021, June) *Bottom-up Curriculum Change: Student Recommendations on More Effective Education about Better Research Practices*, 2021 Meeting of the Society for the Improvement of Psychological Science, Virtual.

Ma de Sousa, A. Q., *Consciousness, Emotion and the Social World*. (2021, June) Talk presented at: The Society for Philosophy and Psychology Annual Meeting, Princeton, NJ (Virtual).

SELECTED POSTER PRESENTATIONS (* indicates trainee)

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2026). How loneliness relates to neural processing of self and other emotion transitions. Social Affective Neuroscience Society Annual Conference; April 17; San Diego, CA.

Tarpar, S.*, **Ma de Sousa A. Q.**, Qin, T., Zhao, S., Chen, A.X., Yu, H. (2026). Shifting Relational Norms Across Time: An Analysis of 19th and 20th Century Corpora in the United States and China. Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2026 Annual Convention; Chicago, Illinois.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Furtado Fernandes, L., Ford, E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2025). Behavioral and neural patterns of predicting emotion transitions: The moderating role of loneliness. Social Affective Neuroscience Society Annual Conference; April 23; Chicago, Illinois.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Schwyck, M. E., Furtado Fernandes, L., Ford, E., Babür, B.G., Lu, C., Zimmerman, J.C., Yu, H., Burns, S. M., Baek, E. C. (2025). Do Lonely Individuals Have Idiosyncratic Neural Representations When Thinking About Their Own and Others' Emotional Transitions? Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2025 Annual Convention; February 22; Denver, Colorado.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Yu, H. (2025). Using Large Language Models to Estimate Relational Norms. Cultural Psychology Preconference; Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2025 Annual Convention; February 22; Denver, Colorado.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Grisco, M.*, Butler, F. V., Padilla-Garcia, D., Ratner, K.G. (2024). Emotional and Motivational Responses to Blatant Prejudice. Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2024 Annual Convention; February 9; San Diego, California.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Chang, J., Lu, C, Li, W., Zhou, X., Yu, H. (2023) How are social emotions computed in relational contexts? Society for Affective Science 2023 Annual Meeting; March 30th; Long Beach, California.

Ma de Sousa A. Q., Grisco, M.*, Butler, F. V., Padilla-Garcia, D., Ratner, K.G. (2023). Emotional Responses to Vicarious Racism. Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2023 Annual Convention; February 17; Atlanta, Georgia.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. Butler, F. V., Padilla-Garcia, D., Ratner, K.G. (2022). Emotional Responses to Vicarious Racism. International Society for Research on Emotion Conference; July 18; Los Angeles, California.

Ma de Sousa A.Q., Stillerman, B., Guillard, C.S., Amodio, D. M. (2022) Perceptual dehumanization induces biased reward learning in repeated interactions. Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2022 Annual Convention; February 17; San Francisco, California.

Ma de Sousa A.Q., Stillerman, B., Guillard, C.S., Amodio, D. M. (2021). Perceptual dehumanization induces biased reward learning in repeated interactions. Harvard Women in Psychology Summit, November 12, Virtual.

Ma de Sousa, A. Q., Chang, L., Paauwe, F.S., Engelmann, J.B. (2021). *Effects of Incidental Anxiety on Theory of Mind*. Poster presented at: Social Psychology Preconference, Society for Personality and Social Psychology 2021 Annual Convention; February 10; Virtual.

Ma de Sousa, A. *Consciousness, Emotion and the Social World*. (2019). Poster presented at: The Science of Consciousness Conference; Jun 25-28; Interlaken, Switzerland.

SCIENCE JOURNALISM

Ma de Sousa, A. (2021, October). [How everyday dehumanization influences our empathy and behavior](#). *Cogbites*.

Ma de Sousa, A. (2021, February). [Hanging with the wrong crowd: how those around us affect our morals](#). *Cogbites*.

Jonušaitė, I., Kühn, M., **Ma de Sousa, A.**, Pingouras, A. & Zimmerman, M. (2021). Better Research Practices: Own Your Research Decisions. *ABC Journal*, 11, 40-43.

Ma de Sousa, A. (2020, September 28). [Seven Lessons about Prejudice from Social Neuroscience](#). *Cogbites*.

- Reposted by the [Cognitive Science Society](#)

Ma de Sousa, A. (2020, June 1). [Are specific areas in the brain responsible for specific thoughts and behavior? Examining the modularity debate](#). *Cogbites*.

- Reposted by the [Cognitive Science Society](#), September 7th, 2020

SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

Creator, Co-Host & Producer, *Minds Matter Podcast* (mindsmatterpodcast.com) (May 2020-Present)

Writer & Editor, *Cogbites* (cogbites.org) (April 2020-2022)

SERVICE

Co-President, *Access Grads Leadership Board* (July 2025 – July 2026)

Committee Member, *Social Affective Neuroscience Society Equity, Diversity, Inclusion, and Justice Committee* (Oct 2025 - Present)

Mentor, *Teaching Assistant Advisory Program (TAAP)* (September 2025 – January 2025)

Media & Recruitment Coordinator, *Access Grads Leadership Board* (Sept 2022 – July 2025)

Mentor, *Access Grads* (September 2021 - Present)

Graduate Student Organizer & Founding Member, *ReproducibiliTEA UCSB Chapter* (Jan 2023 - Present)

Panelist, Graduate school preparedness, hosted by CCSP (May 2025)

Panelist, Graduate school experiences, hosted by Access Grads (Feb 2024)

Graduate Student Representative, *UCSB PBS Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Committee* (Dec 2022 – July 2024)

Graduate Student Representative, *UCSB PBS Admissions Committee* (2023 Admissions Cycle)

President, *Cognito Board - Master Brain and Cognitive Science Student Union* (Sept 2020 - Aug 2021)

Head of PR and Communication, *Cognito Board* (2019-2020)

ADHOC REVIEWING

Quarterly Journal of Psychology, Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, European Journal of Psychology Open

MENTORING EXPERIENCE

Srishti Thapar (RA, Honor's thesis student, URCA award, 2025-Present)

Nara Park (RA, 2026-Present)

Ajoonee Sidhu (RA, Honor's thesis student, 2025-Present)

Melina Zachou (Access Grads Mentee 2025-2026)

Jayne Daijo (Access Grads Mentee 2025-2026)

Emily Nartker (Access Grads Mentee 2025-2026)

Jules Oliver (Access Grads Mentee 2024-2026)

Anna-Sofia Guerra (Access Grads Mentee; 2022-2025)

Tara Sarkar (Graduate student mentee, TAAP 2025-Present)

Celine Tsoi (Graduate student mentee 2024-Present)

Meghety Mikhaelian (Access Grads Mentee 2024-2025)

Gabriela Palafox (Access Grads Mentee 2024-2025)

Drake Zimmerman (RA, 2024-Present)

Tianhao Qin (RA, 2024-Present)

Jackeline Hernandez-Cuevas (RA, FRAP Award Winner, 2023-2024)

Jazmin Vazquez (RA, FRAP Award Winner, 2023-2024)
 Julie Acevesamezola (RA, FRAP Award Winner, 2023-2024)
 Sydney Scott (RA, FRAP Award Winner, 2022-2024)
 Isaiah Lopez (FRAP award: Winter 2024)
 Shannon Twomey (RA, 2023-2024)
 Xitlali Velazquez (Access Grads Mentee 2024-2025)
 Kangning Yu (Access Grads Mentee 2023-2024)
 Miles Anim-Appiah (UC-HBCU Summer Intern, Honor's thesis student)
 Maggie Grisco (Honor's thesis student, Gene & Susan Lucas Undergraduate Research Award 2022-2023, URCA award 2022-2023)
 Hannah Yoon (URCA award 2022-2023)
 Luisa Fernanda Escamilla (Access Grads Mentee; 2022-2023)
 Kim Tran (Access Grads Mentee; 2022-2023)
 Irena Wong (RA, FRAP Award; Fall 2022)
 Joseph Chang (RA, FRAP award Spring 2022)
 Jimi Tyszka (RA, FRAP Award; Spring 2022)
 Robert Hinojos (RA, FRAP award; Winter 2022)
 Jordan Nyitrai (Access Grads Mentee; 2021-2022)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor of Record

- | | |
|---|-------------|
| Instructor of Record, PSY102: <i>Introduction to Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Summer 2025 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Student assessment: Mean=4.71; Median=5; n=38 <i>'The instructor explained course material in a way that helped me learn'</i>
(scale: 5=strongly agree; 1=strongly disagree) | |
| Instructor of Record, PSY102: <i>Introduction to Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Summer 2024 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Average Student Assessment: Mean=4.85; Median=5; n=27 | |

Teaching Assistant

- | | |
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| Teaching Assistant, PSY150L: <i>Lab in Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Spring 2026 |
| Teaching Assistant, PSY10B: <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , UCSB | Winter 2026 |
| Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY102: <i>Introduction to Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Fall 2025 |
| Teaching Assistant, PSY150L: <i>Lab in Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Spring 2025 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Average Student Assessment: Mean=5; Median=5; n=4 <i>'How helpful were the TA's explanations of course material?'</i>
(scale: 5=very helpful; 1=not helpful) | |
| Teaching Assistant, PSY10B: <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , UCSB | Winter 2025 |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> Average Student Assessment: Mean=4.8; Median=5; n=5 <i>'How helpful were the TA's explanations of course material?'</i>
(scale: 5=very helpful; 1=not helpful) | Fall 2024 |
| Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY10B: <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , UCSB | Fall 2024 |
| Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY1: <i>Introduction to Psychology</i> , UCSB | Spring 2024 |
| Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY102: <i>Introduction to Social Psychology</i> , UCSB | Winter 2024 |
| Teaching Assistant, PSY10B: <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , UCSB | Spring 2023 |

Teaching Assistant, PSY10B: <i>Introduction to Statistics</i> , UCSB	Winter 2023
Average Student Assessment: Mean=1; Median=1; n=5 (scale: 1=excellent; 5=poor)	
Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY152: <i>Social Cognition</i> , UCSB	Fall 222
Teaching Assistant (Admin), PSY150L: <i>Lab in Social Psychology</i> , UCSB	Spring 2022
Teaching Assistant, Introduction to Statistics, UCSB	Winter 2022
Average Student Assessment: Mean=1; Median=1; n=9 (scale: 1=excellent; 5=poor)	
Teaching Assistant, PSY100: <i>Introduction to Psychology</i> , UC Santa Barbara	Fall 2021
Average Student Assessment: Mean=1.36; Median=1; n=52 (scale: 1=excellent; 5=poor)	
Teaching Assistant, <i>Milestones, Promises & Pitfalls</i> , University of Amsterdam	Fall 2020
Average Student Assessment: 9/10	

GUEST LECTURES

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Statistics*. (2026, May). Invited Guest Lecture, Lab in Social Psychology (UCSB): Prof. David Sherman.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science*. (2026, March). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Intergroup Relations*. (2025, May). Invited Guest Lecture, Social Neuroscience Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science* (2024, October). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Replication & Open Science*. (2024, April). Invited Guest Lecture, Introduction to Social Psychology Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

Ma de Sousa A. Q. *Intergroup Relations*. (2024, February). Invited Guest Lecture, Social Neuroscience Course (UCSB): Prof. Hongbo Yu.

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

International Society for Research on Emotion	2022-Present
European Society for Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience	2025-Present
Social Affective Neuroscience Society	2022-Present
Society for Affective Science	2021-Present
Society for Personality and Social Psychology	2020-Present

OTHER SKILLS

Languages: English (Native), French (Native), Spanish (Intermediate), Mandarin (Intermediate-Spoken; Basic-written), Italian (Intermediate), German (Basic), Dutch (Basic)

Statistical Software: R, JASP, SPSS

Programming Languages: Python, Matlab, JavaScriptBacktraBa

Neuroimaging software & Packages: FSL, SPM, xjview, MRICroGL

Other Software and Packages: Psiturk, Amazon MTurk, Inquisit, E-Prime

Online Research Platforms: Survey Monkey, Qualtrics